electrical appliances and transport equipment.

Mekong Ganga Cooperation: Myanmar is a member of the Mekong Ganga Cooperation (MGC) since its inception in November 2000. MGC is an initiative by six countries – India and five ASEAN countries namely, Cambodia, Laos, Myanmar, Thailand and Vietnam – for cooperation in the fields of tourism, education, culture, transport and communication. The chairmanship of MGC is assumed by member countries in alphabetical order.

SAARC: Myanmar was given the status of observer in SAARC in August 2008.

1. In India, we often say Myanmar is our "gateway" to the East. Against the rhetoric, the existing connectivity between the two neighbours remains much to be desired. With long land and maritime boundaries, the neighbours are yet to take full advantage of geography.
2. Historically, India has been a major player in Myanmar's socio-economic landscape till the 1960s. The advent of military dictatorship and its economic policies reduced India's interactions with Myanmar.
3. As the political transition in Myanmar picks up momentum, it provides an excellent opportunity to explore new avenues of cooperation.

10.9 India – Maldives Relations



The archipelago of Maldives consists of 1192 islands of which roughly 200 islands are inhabited with an estimated population of 430,000 and 80 islands with tourist resorts. The capital Male is the hot seat of Maldives' power and is also the most populated Island. Being a completely Sunni Muslim country with a liberal following, Islam is the only state religion and practising of other religions are strictly private affairs within the homes.

The first state level visit was in 1974 when Prime Minister Mr Ahmed Zaki of Maldives made an official visit to India.

India - Maldives formal relations began with the declaration of Maldivian independence in November 1965. India was the first country to recognise Maldives. After which there has been frequent visits by the leaders of both countries. Most of these visits have benefited Maldives economically.

This cordial relationship continued even during President Nasheed tenure. President Nasheed's maiden international trip after coming to power was to India in 2008. During this visit, India promised a $100 million loan to improve the tourism industry in Maldives. Since then there have been frequent visits by officials and President Nasheed to New Delhi until 2012 when President Nasheed was overthrown in a bloodless coup.



Mohamed Nasheed

Maldives importance to India: Security

- **Geostrategic Location:** Maldives is located just 700 km from the strategic Lakshadweep island chain and 1,200 km from the Indian mainland, and the growing Chinese presence in the archipelago could have serious security implications.

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